CHAPTER 22

CHANGING OF THE GUARD

13 March 2008

NEW ZEALAND vs ENGLAND, 2nd Test, *Basin Reserve, Wellington*

England won by 126 runs

We have lost the week before in New Zealand and the press have been out for blood. I hadn't played and neither had Stuart Broad. I'd been in Auckland while the team were playing in Hamilton. They had asked for Chris Tremlett, who hadn't wanted to go. Realising I was just going to be carrying the drinks around, I stuck my hand up. 'I want to play cricket,' I said. 'I'll go.' I got 2–80 off 38 overs, not exactly setting the world on fire, but I just enjoyed the process of bowling again. When I come back, it is to find a fractious and discontented England squad, scrapping amongst themselves. We have just had a net session the morning before the second game, at the Bay Reserve in Wellington. In this environment it feels like the nets are a sort of audition, coaches hanging around at both sides of the nets watching intently, with the body language and whispering as if they are picking the team on what they are seeing there and then.

As the new coach Peter Moores calls players in to tell them the news, many leave stone-faced, kicking the ground or wincing into the distance. When it's the bowlers' turn – always last – I enter and those selected are reeled off in batting order. Broad, Sidebottom, Panesar, Anderson. There's a silence after it, like a machete has sliced through time itself, marking a difference between then (up until a minute ago) and now. Peter Moores even leaves a slightly stunned silence for himself at the end of the list of names, almost half-impressed and half-shocked about what he'd just